

IN CONTEXT

The Thirty Years' War

Magdeburg, devastated during the Thirty Years' War (1618–1648), was in ruins when Telemann was a boy. Memories of bloodshed and famine, the legacy of the Protestant city's destruction by Catholic forces in 1631, haunted its people. The shadow of civil war focused German minds on promoting national and international peace via commerce and the arts.

German composers contributed to the harmony of nations by creating what became known as the “mixed taste,” a union of different styles. Telemann proved a musical alchemist, able to transform what he called “French liveliness ... Italian flattery ... and the British and Polish jesting”.



THE FALL OF MAGDEBURG IN 1631, DURING
THE THIRTY YEARS' WAR

During his lifetime, Georg Philipp Telemann was Germany's leading composer. His output was vast: he wrote almost 40 operas, more than 1,000 church cantatas, around 125 overture-